The reptile house

Reptiles are scaly-skinned, "cold-blooded" creatures with a bony skeleton and a backbone. They live on land, in freshwater, and in the sea. There are four main groups of reptiles alive today.



Desert tortoises

Tortoises live on land. Turtles and terrapins live in the sea (saltwater) or in rivers and ponds (freshwater).

The *Chelonia* group

Tortoises, turtles, and terrapins are known as *Chelonians*. All members of this group, or "order," have a body that is protected by a shell.

Squamata everywhere!

The *Squamata* order contains every single species of lizard and snake. It is by far the largest group of living reptiles. Amazingly, nearly all reptiles are lizards and snakes.

Snakes may have had legs for digging down, but now

All Crocodilian *reptiles, like these crocodiles, have tough, armorlike skin covering their entire bodies.*



The *Crocodilians*

Crocodiles, alligators, caimans, and gharials all belong to the *Crocodilia* group. Most make their homes in warm freshwater rivers, lakes, and swamps.